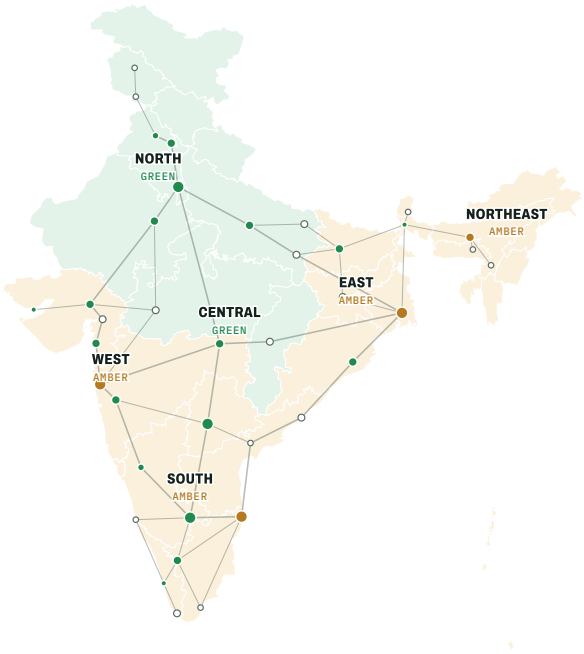
INB INDIA NETWORK BULLETIN · EDITION 017 FRIDAY 23 OCTOBER 2026 · 09:00 IST

Small towns lift festive sales, and a Bay low forms

● NETWORK: AMBER

Bank of America puts this season's online sales 25-29% above last year's, with small-town and first-time buyers doing the lifting. IMD gives a high chance of a depression in the Bay of Bengal by Sunday, and has asked ports on the east coast to get ready. Kolkata's immersion bans end tomorrow, and Mandya's farmers plan to block the Bengaluru–Mysuru highway today.

HOW'S EACH REGION HOLDING UP?



Map: DataMeet, CC BY 4.0

DATES TO WATCH

● 23–24 Oct	Kolkata immersion bans on goods vehicles
● Fri 23 Oct	Farmers plan to block the Bengaluru–Mysuru highway
● 23–24 Oct	Air India and IndiGo Saudi flights cancelled
● Sun 25 Oct	Petrapole–Benapole reopens to cargo
● Sun 25 Oct	Bay low likely to become a depression
● Mon 26 Oct	Karnataka cane price meeting in Belagavi
● 26–27 Oct	Kolkata immersion bans, second round
● 26 Oct–5 Nov	NH-10 night closures
● Tue 27 Oct	Cane growers threaten a strike
● Sun 1 Nov	Delhi keeps out non-BS-VI vehicles from outside
● Sun 1 Nov	CMA CGM's new North Europe–India rates
● Sun 1 Nov	Ethanol year starts without sugar-based ethanol

● GREEN the sale season as usual, which can still be busy

● AMBER something beyond the season is slowing freight

● RED something is stopping freight across a state or a route

North ● GREEN

Nothing beyond the season is holding up the north's trucks this morning, so Delhi, Ludhiana and Jaipur see no delay beyond the season.

West ● AMBER

Thursday's count at JNPA's container freight stations was back up to 13,547 TEU, from 10,405[1,2]. The pile for inland trains barely moved, mind you, at 3,901[1]. I'd expect Nhava Sheva's import boxes to reach their buyers a day or two late into next week, and the yard to stay busy till both queues clear.

South ● AMBER

IMD keeps heavy to very heavy rain on Tamil Nadu to the 26th, after 12 to 20 cm fell in a day, and adds coastal Andhra early next week[3]. KRRS has called a shutdown of the Bengaluru–Mysuru highway at Gananguru today[4], and Belagavi's cane growers say they'll strike again from Tuesday unless Monday's meeting with the Chief Minister brings a price[5]. I'd expect Chennai's deliveries to slip a day through the weekend, and Mysuru loads to lose a few hours today.

East ● AMBER

Kolkata's goods vehicles sit out the last two nights of immersion bans tonight and tomorrow, and two more on the 26th and 27th[6]. Odisha's coast is next, with squalls of up to 60 kmph forecast early next week as the Bay system nears[3]. I'd expect Kolkata's held parcels to reach doorsteps from Sunday, and Odisha's coastal roads to slow from Tuesday if the squalls come.

Northeast ● AMBER

Andhra's lorry owners have asked the Finance Ministry and CBIC to free trucks held at the Assam–Bengal border for days, some for over a month, The Hindu reports[7]. About half carry Assam petroleum coke for Visakhapatnam, the rest for Haldia, Durgapur, Barauni and Paradip, and the owners put the demurrage at about ₹1 crore[7]. With the owners still writing to Delhi, I'd expect Visakhapatnam's carbon plants to stay short of coke into next week.

Central ● GREEN

Pithampur's residents held up the Mhow–Neemuch road on Thursday morning over five days of power cuts, with a kilometre of traffic behind them, Bhaskar English reports[8]. It was a morning's protest outside Indore's industrial belt, so central India's freight sees no delay beyond the season.

NETWORK INSIGHTS

1 Online festive sales run 25-29% above last year, Bank of America estimates

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

Bank of America estimates this season's online sales at 25-29% above last year's, from Datum Intelligence's figures, Fortune India reports[9]. Its note, as Business Standard reads it, credits shoppers outside the metros and first-time buyers, over a sale window running to 15 November[10]. Meesho's orders rose about 75% on its sale's first day, and Meesho Mall's buyers from Tier 3 and smaller towns nearly tripled[10]. So where does the extra volume go? Mostly to towns at the far end of the long haul, the slowest leg to add trucks to. Delivery complaints in Amazon's Play Store reviews eased a little, to 29 of 221 on the 21st from 37 of 216 the day before[11]. I'd expect the regional hubs feeding Tier 3 towns to run full until mid-November, with the last leg into those towns running a day behind, and Diwali's own orders landing on top from early November.

> **Brands selling online that are growing fastest in small towns carry the most risk of a late doorstep, because the extra orders land on the thinnest leg of the network. Carriers and 3PLs serving Tier 3 towns need extra trucks on routes that run half empty the rest of the year, and pay market rates for them till mid-November.**

2 Most of Zepto's Navratri orders came on the day of the event

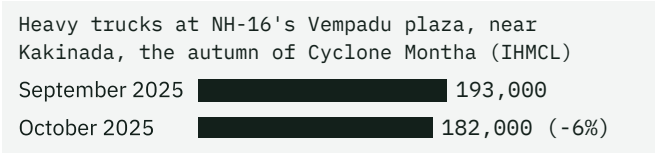
MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

About seven in ten of Zepto's festive essentials were ordered on the day of the Garba nights they were for, BusinessLine reports, so the stock had to sit in its dark stores by that morning[12]. Dandiya sticks peaked at 6 pm on the 16th, Zepto's festive wear orders grew 400%, and Swiggy's sweet orders rose 36% from the 17th to the 20th on last year[12]. So when does a festival hit quick commerce? By the hour, on the day itself. I'd expect Diwali's eve to run the same way, with dark stores needing festival stock in place by the morning and their restocking trucks busiest the night before.

> **Quick commerce platforms, and the brands selling through them, carry a stock-out risk measured in hours, not days: a dark store restocked a day late misses the festival. Carriers and 3PLs running warehouse-to-store trucks get their heaviest nights just before each festival, with Diwali the biggest.**

3 IMD expects a depression in the Bay by Sunday, and asks ports to prepare

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE



A low is likely over the southeast Bay of Bengal today, and IMD gives a high chance of it becoming a depression by Sunday morning, Kalinga TV reports from its Bhubaneswar bulletin[13]. IMD has asked shipping, port and offshore operators to review their preparedness for 23-29 October[13]. Where would it come ashore? Nobody knows yet: some foreign models point between north Andhra and south Odisha, but IMD has forecast no cyclone, Odisha TV reports[14]. And what did last year's storm do? When Cyclone Montha crossed near Kakinada on 28 October 2025, Andhra stopped traffic on every road in seven districts overnight[15]. That October NH-16's Vempadu plaza, near Kakinada, counted 182,000 heavy trucks, 6% fewer than September's 193,000[16,17]. I'd expect Visakhapatnam, Kakinada and Paradip to lose a day or two of loading, and NH-16 trucks a night, if a storm comes ashore there between Tuesday and Thursday.

> **Manufacturers and exporters with cargo through Visakhapatnam, Kakinada or Paradip next week risk a lost berth day and a missed vessel. Carriers and 3PLs on NH-16, and brands selling online with Diwali stock on that road, face a night or more of held trucks.**

4 Warehouse leasing rises 26% this year, fastest in Pune and Bengaluru

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

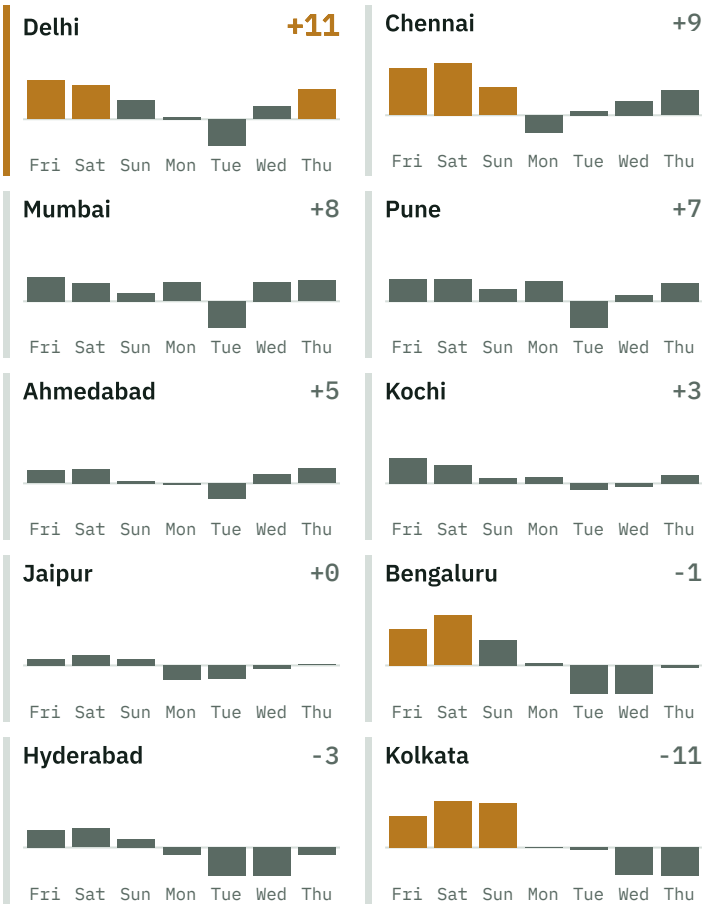
Grade A warehouse leasing in India's eight big markets reached 33.3 million sq ft from January to September, up 26%, with 3PLs taking about a third, Colliers India reports in The Federal[18]. Pune's leasing rose 70% and Bengaluru's 61%, Mumbai's alone fell, by 14%, and new supply ran ahead of demand, lifting vacancy to 16% with rents largely flat[18]. A warehouse leased this year is, of course, next year's origin hub, and the trucks follow it. I'd expect more of 2027's linehaul to start in Pune and Bengaluru and less in Mumbai, and 3PLs to find more choice of space, though not cheaper rents.

> **Carriers and 3PLs that plan next year's lanes from this year's flows will be short of trucks out of Pune and Bengaluru, where the new space is filling fastest. Manufacturers and brands selling online get more space to choose from at steady rents, so moving stock closer to buyers costs no more in rent than it did.**

CITY TRAFFIC UPDATES

City roads against usual, daily, 16–22 Oct[19] amber = 10+ over

Delhi's evening crowds round the Ramlila and Puja grounds, which its traffic police had warned of, lifted the 16th and 17th[20], and the Old RTR flyover's closure on the airport side, for crack repairs, the 22nd[21]. Kolkata stayed high through the Puja's first days under the police's road closures[6], Chennai through the very heavy rain of the 16th to 18th[22] and again after Tuesday night's downpour, which left OMR and Taramani–Velachery Road waterlogged till 11 am[23], and Bengaluru as the Dasara holiday traffic headed out of town[24].



HOW MY CALLS HAVE DONE

Of the 5 calls scored so far, 4 came true, 1 partly and none was wrong. 4 are still open. From 12 Oct:

1. The state retailers hold diesel prices through 19th October, while Jio-bp's and Nayara's stay ₹3 a litre higher. **Right.** No change reported at the state pumps; Nayara and Jio-bp charge ₹3 more. Source
2. Delhi's BS-IV exemption has not been extended by 19th October. **Right.** Gurugram police confirmed the 1 November cut-off on the 16th. Source

HOW THIS IS MADE

At 7 every morning, Claude drafts this page on its own using data available from public sources only. It reads the morning's public signals: city traffic in ten cities, the JNPA and Paradip port reports, ship queues at the container ports, toll-plaza truck counts, the seasonal calendar and about twenty news searches.

Then it writes, and a set of checks decides whether the draft is even fit for me to read. Every claim has to be opened and cited, and no source can be over a week old without a reason. No story from the last seven days comes back unless it actually moved, and nothing gets said twice.

I read it, argue with it, fix what's wrong and approve it. The ratings are my judgement on the likelihood of on-time delivery or cost-impact, not measured service levels or actual cost estimates. Confidence is High when the facts are dated and primary or measured, Medium when they rest on a proxy or a forecast. Does that make the page right? Not always, which is why the calls get scored.

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SOURCES

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15. The News Minute: Cyclone Montha's landfall continues near Kakinada, 29 Oct 2025
16. IHMCL: FASTag heavy-vehicle counts by toll plaza, September 2025
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20. Business Today: Delhi traffic police warn of evening delays till 20 Oct, 17 Oct
21. The Pioneer: Old RTR flyover carriageway towards Vasant Vihar closed until 25 Oct, 22 Oct
22. IMD press release: extremely heavy rain over Tamil Nadu, 18 Oct
23. DT Next: waterlogging, uprooted trees and battered roads in Chennai after overnight rain, 22 Oct
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